

 GROWTH CARTOGRAPHY • FIELD GUIDE 001

A \$1.3 TRILLION INDUSTRY. 2.5 SECONDS OF ATTENTION.

Introducing The CMO's Field Guide to System & Cohort Dynamics: a map of the machine that now decides who sees you, and what it costs when it stops looking.

THE PARADOX FUNDING MODERN MARKETING

\$1.3T

what the world will spend on
advertising in 2026

2.5s

active attention the average digital
ad actually earns

 PART ONE

THE SIGNAL FLOOD

Why reach stopped working, and why buying more of it makes the problem worse.

01

DAILY AD EXPOSURE, THEN AND NOW

~500

ads a day in the 1970s

10,000

ads a day now. Exposure grew 20×;
human attention did not

THE FLOOD HAS A SECOND-ORDER EFFECT

Disillusionomics

/ dɪs·ɪˌluː·ʒənˈɒm·ɪks / noun

When the machinery of persuasion becomes visible, consumers **price it in**. Every tactic they can see is a tactic they discount, and baseline trust in marketing resets lower.

■ COMPOUNDING COHORT DECAY EATS UNBALANCED BUDGETS

44%

of companies focus mainly on
acquisition

16%

focus mainly on retention, while
every acquired cohort starts
decaying on day one

■ RECALIBRATE THE INSTRUMENT

THE OLD MAP VS THE NEW TERRAIN

THE OLD MAP

Campaigns that end

Reach and impressions

Last-click credit

Microscopic targeting

A rebrand per trend

THE NEW TERRAIN

→ Cohorts that compound, or decay

→ Active attention, measured in seconds

→ Shapley-value attribution

→ Market thickness

→ One persistent identity

 PART TWO

THE TURN

If attention is scarce and trust is discounted,
what's left to build on?

02

“

Identity has thus become **the ultimate infrastructure**, not identity in the narrow sense of brand guidelines and logo placement, but a persistent, coherent, recognizable self that people can form a durable relationship with across channels, contexts, and time. Because belief lives in culture and trust lives in experience, persistent identity is **the connective tissue** required to bridge the two.

■ HUMANS HAVE ORGANIZED AROUND SHARED BELIEF FOR ~70,000 YEARS*

THE PLATFORMS CHANGED. THE PHYSICS DIDN'T.

BELIEF

lives in culture

People adopt what their cohort already believes.
No ad unit outruns the group.

TRUST

lives in experience

Every touchpoint, from chatbot to checkout, either compounds trust or spends it.

IDENTITY

bridges the two

One persistent, recognizable self is the only asset that works on both sides.

■ THE CMO ACTION PLAN

SIX IMPERATIVES FOR 2026

01

Rebalance toward retention

Acquisition-only budgets refill a leaking map. Fund structural retention before the cohort is gone.

02

Adopt Shapley-value attribution

Last-click is structurally gameable. Credit the whole journey with game-theoretic attribution.

03

Set rational constraints

Impossible ROAS targets don't push algorithms harder. They trigger clipping and throttle delivery.

04

Make AI use visibly ethical

Transparency is now brand equity. Private, provable data handling beats clever targeting.

05

Preserve market thickness

Hyper-granular targeting collapses reach and distorts price floors. Target culture, not microdots.

06

Treat identity as infrastructure

No reactive pivots. One coherent self across every touchpoint, platform, and year.

■ EVERY FIGURE, ONE PLACE TO CHECK

SOURCES & METHODOLOGY

01

WARC · Global Ad Forecasts, Dec 2025

\$1.3 trillion global ad spend in 2026

warc.com ↗

03

CBS News / Yankelovich · Cutting Through Advertising Clutter

~500 ads a day in the 1970s, rising toward 10,000 today

cbsnews.com ↗

05

Econsultancy · Cross-Channel Marketing Report

44% focus on acquisition vs 16% on retention

econsultancy.com ↗

BORROWED FRAMEWORKS · CREDITED IN FULL

A

The ~70,000-year "shared belief" framing is Yuval Noah Harari's Cognitive Revolution thesis from **Sapiens**, paraphrased here and credited to Harari.

02

Dr Karen Nelson-Field / Amplified · Why Does the Attention-Memory Threshold Matter?

2.5s of active attention is where memory encoding begins. Most digital ads never reach it.

amplified.co ↗

04

Fortune, Jan 2026 · Disillusionomics (Alice Lassman)

The term for consumers pricing in visible persuasion

fortune.com ↗

B

"Disillusionomics" is a term coined by economist Alice Lassman, popularized via **Fortune, Jan 2026**.



THE MAP KEEPS UNFOLDING.

Three more field guides are on the way: Aggregated, Decentralized, Autonomous. Here is how to get them, and how to put them to work.

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Test & model the outcomes → github.com/jratlee/FDI

BUILT ON THE FDI SLIDE SYSTEM

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